

## Using dissonance

Consonance isn't "good" and dissonance "bad" despite them being referred to as "perfect" and "imperfect" intervals. In 1921, the American composer Charles Ives caught the mood-music of the times with his song "Majority," which uses great dissonance to symbolize revolutionary political ideas. The song begins with the lyrics, "The Masses have toiled. Behold the works of the world".

### ▽ Opening of "Majority" by Ives

The chords in the boxes contain nine different notes of the chromatic scale. You cannot hear each note separately, just as you cannot see each person in a large crowd.

In common with music written on the edge of, or outside, tonality, the song is notated in C, which means that every accidental is individually marked.

Only C $\sharp$ , F $\sharp$ , and G $\sharp$  are missing from this chord. Playing it requires either two pianists or "spreading" the chord so that the notes in the bass clef are played before those in the treble clef.

### LOOKING CLOSER

#### Tritone

Not all fourths and fifths are perfect. A perfect fourth lies five half steps apart, while a perfect fifth is separated by seven half steps no matter what the scale or starting note is. The note that lies in between is the tritone, an augmented fourth, which is six half steps apart. In most Western music, the tritone creates a fierce dissonance that demands resolution. In jazz, however, the tritone is commonly used as a stable interval.



Augmented 4<sup>th</sup>

well with the world!

**Conclusion of "Majority" by Ives**  
The song ends with the lyrics, "All will be well with the world," on a soft F major chord. Here, Ives is using consonance to symbolize rest and resolution.